

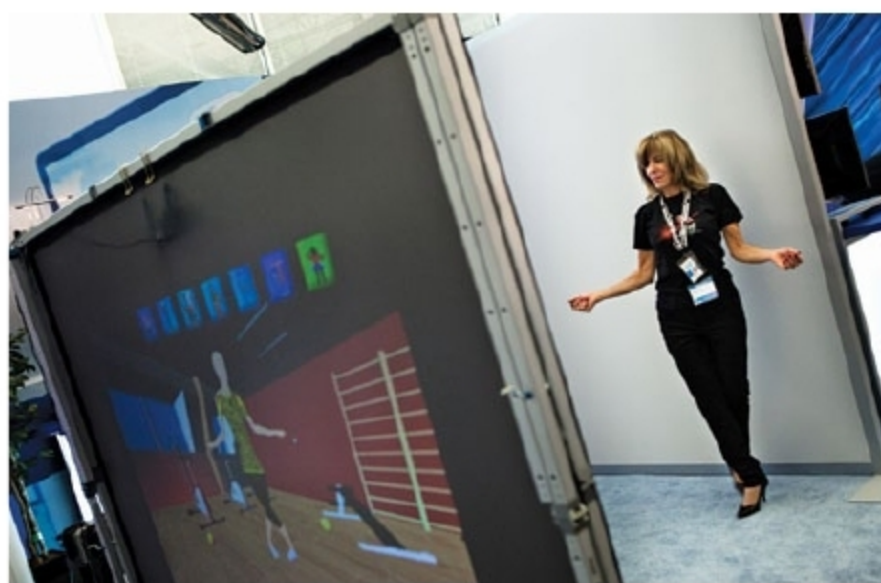
using an Oculus Rift headset, to launch Capra hiking boots. It was a 4D, motion-tracked, multi-sensory virtual experience that simulated extreme landscapes like wobbly bridges and landslides. Motion-capture technology put adventurers into scenarios they would not normally encounter on a hike.

Easing the buying decision. Using VR, retailers facilitate shoppers making purchase decisions even where they cannot physically interact with the products. **eBay Australia launched the world's first virtual department store.** With the help of Google Cardboard headset, called Shoptical, shoppers could view 3D images of products, and examine different features, colours and materials, getting the familiar physical shopping experience. It allowed users to browse, sort and engage with items of interest by just looking at them. It generated invaluable data for eBay to analyse what catches the shoppers' attention and how they browse in a VR space.

When product prices are high, one hesitates in making decision to spend money. For example, booking a costly holiday trip entails considerable exploration to decide tour plans and make a financial commitment. What if one gets to experience various travel destinations without actually travelling there?

Thomas Cook, a travel agency, provided potential vacationers opportunity to explore a series of virtual holidays through Samsung Gear VR. They created Try Before You Fly, 360-degree VR films showcasing available holidaying opportunities. They even made travellers experience helicopter tours for such sites as Egyptian pyramids. To complement the in-store experience, Thomas Cook created an app to view the content from the comfort of home. The VR experience created immense interest and generated about US\$ 15,600, a forty per cent return on investment.

Building an intelligent testing environment. Retailers combine virtual environments and shopper analytics to improve store layout, marketing displays, product packaging



Intel Magic Mirror, a virtual fitting room (Credit: <http://newsroom.intel.com>)

and customer journey. Smith Brothers, USA, developed day- and night-time cough drops. They successfully used a virtual store to test the developed product, validate packaging and measure expected performance of the product. The test enabled Smith Brothers to improve the product before finally launching it into market.

Virtual fitting rooms. Many shoppers consider trying on clothing inconvenient and time-consuming, feel embarrassed asking for a trial room or are simply lazy to take off shoes and clothes. AR-based virtual fitting rooms are a cost-effective solution to get such reluctant shoppers try products, enhance shoppers' convenience, improve shopping experience and promote business.

Timberland set up a virtual fitting room in Warsaw, Poland, for virtually trying-on the products without going into a dressing room, using a magic mirror in which, the shopper and objects around were augmented on a 2.03m (80-inch) screen. They could take pictures using cellphones



Snapshot from Lacoste LCST AR retail campaign (Credit: www.enginecreative.co.uk)

for sharing on social media. Images were displayed on shopping windows too, to drive more foot traffic. **Virtual fitting rooms are a game changer as they have changed the way traditional and digital marketing operates.**

French clothing company Lacoste launched 3D AR app to trigger interactive 3D models of the new range of LCST trainer shoes. To virtually try out the trainer shoes, shoppers placed their foot on the in-store floor graphic

and scanned it with a smartphone. The shoe image was superimposed around their feet without having to wait for a shop assistant or taking off their shoes. They could examine the features and swipe to view other trainers in the range. They could also share images via social media.

Italian beauty retailer Sephora launched an AR mirror that enabled shoppers to virtually put makeup on images of their faces and like in real life, mix and match different shades of cosmetics by tapping a palette on the screen.

Ikea created its Ikea Catalogue app to develop AR images of products, which appeared on mobile screen as if they were in the customers' home. This enabled customers to virtually try out various products for size, shape, colour and positioning to see how the products would actually fit into the room.

Volvo uses AR for its customers to view the inner components and features of a Volvo model using Volvo X-ray app, turning their iPads into portable x-ray scanners. Customers can see underneath the car's exteriors, inner mechanics and components, as well as explore the car's features through a 360-degree viewing element.

Starbucks offers customers an app for an immersive in-store AR experience in Starbucks Reserve Roastery in Shanghai. The experience includes an online marketplace, Tmall, where shoppers can purchase merchandise or experience the specially-curated coffee. Starbucks is also trying out VR technology to transport viewers to coffee farms in various countries to make them feel confident about the